

United States District Court for the District of South Carolina

Piedmont Booksellers Guild v. City of Norvale

Case No. SYN-DSC-26-CV-0107 · Police Logistics Declaration

Filed January 14, 2026

I, Lieutenant Rowan Pike, declare from personal knowledge as follows. I serve as the Norvale Police Department's special-events logistics coordinator. I have been a sworn officer for fourteen years and have held this assignment since 2022. My duties include reviewing planned street and park activity for vehicle conflicts, pedestrian crossings, officer availability, emergency access, and overlap with other scheduled demands. I do not approve literary content, determine which authors may appear, or review whether the Department agrees with an announced subject.

When the parks office circulates an event plan, I first consider its date, hours, total expected attendance, loading window, entrances, seating, and any requested street control. A presentation schedule may help identify a short interval when people will converge near one path or leave together. I may recommend cones, a crossing presence, a different unloading cutoff, or separation between a queue and a bus boarding area. A recommendation must identify the operational fact supporting it. General concern that listeners might dislike lawful speech is not a police-planning basis.

I reviewed Department dispatch abstracts, event notes, and the Cedar Commons site materials relevant to the Piedmont Booksellers Guild. I also have observed portions of community events at the Commons, though I have not attended every Guild fair from beginning to end. My testimony distinguishes records I reviewed from conditions I personally saw. It is offered to describe planning needs, not to characterize the Guild as disorderly or to predict misconduct by its authors or audience.

Recorded Conditions at Guild Fairs

The police records supplied for review contain no arrest, fight, property-damage report, or violent event attributed to a Guild fair. Two minor medical calls are associated with fair dates. One concerned an attendee who became dizzy during warm weather; the other concerned a person who fell near a curb. Neither abstract reports evacuation, a criminal act, or a prolonged closure. I do not rely on those calls as evidence that paid speakers create violence.

The more frequent concern is ordinary movement. Market Lane carries through traffic while sellers unload boxes and display materials. A vehicle that remains at the curb beyond the unloading interval can cause another driver to wait or maneuver around it. Near the fountain, the library walk narrows relative to the central lawn. When a reading finishes, some listeners move toward vendor tables or a signing location while other pedestrians continue toward the library or bus areas. The available notes describe temporary congestion, not gridlock.

These conditions matter because an unobstructed route can shorten a response and because a driver or pedestrian conflict may arise without producing a dispatch entry. Preventive work is difficult to measure from call records alone. At the same time, no continuous counts were taken, and the files do not quantify every delay. I cannot assign all observed congestion to presentations; unloading, tent placement, ordinary shopping, transit schedules, weather, and adjacent activity can contribute.

Guild volunteers and City employees have generally corrected problems through directions. Boxes have been moved, vendors have completed unloading, and the service approach has remained usable during the medical responses described in the file. That history supports the feasibility of modest controls. It does not establish that planning is unnecessary, and it does not establish that a speaker's identity or topic predicts a particular police need.

Advance Information and Staffing

Special-event assignments compete with patrol coverage, training, court appearances, and other public events. Forty-five days usually gives supervisors time to compare a proposed schedule with known demands, decide whether a requested post is necessary, and notify parks staff of a conflict. The Department does not need forty-five days for every ordinary reading, and a simple unchanged plan can be reviewed more quickly. The value of advance notice is that the potentially affected period is available before assignments become difficult to adjust.

For police logistics, the strongest information is a presentation's starting time, likely duration, location, expected number of listeners, equipment, and relationship to unloading or transit activity. A name helps identify the slot when organizers later refer to a replacement. A short topic or format phrase may indicate that the activity is a reading, panel, demonstration, or question period; police personnel neither need nor request the speaker's opinions. Compensation is not a reliable estimate of drawing power. I have no basis to say a paid writer always attracts more people than an unpaid speaker.

The ordinance's paid-speaker classification tells the permitting office that the organizer has arranged a scheduled program rather than incidental table conversation. Once a file reaches me, I assess the actual logistics. A sixth compensated author added within the same hours does not automatically require another officer. It could add a transition to the schedule, or it could simply replace an existing slot. The resulting need depends on the changed facts.

The Department has not calculated a police expense of \$45 for reviewing each speaker. That amount was set as an administrative assessment by the City, not as reimbursement for a particular officer. If dedicated personnel are justified for an event, any separate charge must be supported under the applicable rules. My declaration supports the City's planning interest but should not be read as a fee-accounting opinion.

February Planning and Practical Limits

I understand that the Guild's announced 2026 dates are February 14, April 11, June 13, August 8, October 10, and December 12. The recurring nature of the series allows staff to begin with a familiar layout, yet conditions can vary by season and by competing demands. For the February date, I can evaluate an established presentation area, an attendance range, a loading cutoff, and a proposed schedule even if every author is not yet known. A later change still should be reported if it alters a time, audience estimate, format, location, or equipment request.

Several measures could address the record before me without a broad police presence. Cones may clarify the Market Lane loading edge; signs may keep the fountain approach open; chairs and signing activity may be separated; vendors may receive a firm vehicle-removal time; and an emergency corridor may be marked before setup. A crossing post should be recommended only if traffic information and the expected interval support it. I have not concluded that the ordinary Guild layout requires dedicated officers throughout a fair.

There is a legitimate operational benefit in knowing a stable schedule before supervisors finalize assignments. There is also a meaningful difference between a replacement who occupies an unchanged twenty-minute slot and a new program expected to draw a substantially larger audience or extend the event. A review process can take that difference into account. Whether the existing ordinance states that distinction with sufficient precision is outside my expertise.

My conclusions are limited. The Guild's history is peaceful, the two medical calls were minor, and the documented congestion was routinely managed. Those facts weigh against exaggerated predictions. They do not relieve the City of prospective traffic and access responsibilities. I have not considered any author's ideology, and I know of no police request to restrict a Guild presentation because of its message. I declare under penalty of perjury that these statements are true and correct. Executed January 14, 2026, at Norvale, South Carolina.